The paper was especially active during the Berlin Blockade, the first major international crises of the Cold War, sparked when the USSR cut off the Western Allies' rail, road and canal access to the sectors of Berlin under Western control. Everything, not just foodstuffs, but coal, gasoline, clothing and a staggering range of supplies for 2 million people had to be flown in. Day in, day out, week after week for fifteen months, British and American transport planes, army and civil, flew to West Berlin. A flight every ninety seconds was the average, with turnaround – landing, unloading and taking-off – averaging six to seven minutes.26

With mounting irritability, Junge Welt also fumed during the creation of NATO, as battle lines were drawn between East and West. At the same time, as Soviet and Western zones became politically, economically and socially more like their respective occupying powers, mistrust and suspicion grew.

Before long, two divergent Germanys had developed without direct reference to the German people themselves, as their destiny played out against the background of American–Soviet rivalry. When the Berlin airlift began, the United States and Britain had already agreed to establish a West German state as a federal parliamentary republic – which was formally born in Bonn during May 1949, with Konrad Adenauer as chancellor. As integration with the West developed as the foundation of Adenauer policy, West Germany became a major recipient of reconstruction aid under the Marshall Plan.

Amid this mass of seething tension, the SED screamed about Bonn's new 'separatist government' and set about establishing the 'German Democratic Republic' (GDR) across the territory administered by Soviet forces. Predictably, Junge Welt sat at the forefront of a full-scale propaganda campaign, reporting that works' councils, political party leaders and workers' organisations demanded that the communist-led 'People's Council' should proceed immediately with the formation of a German Democratic Republic. Honecker commissioned leading articles by communist leaders to denounce in savage and blistering phrases the FRG parliament at Bonn. 'The time had come,' it was said, for the 'Bonn